



Yacare caiman

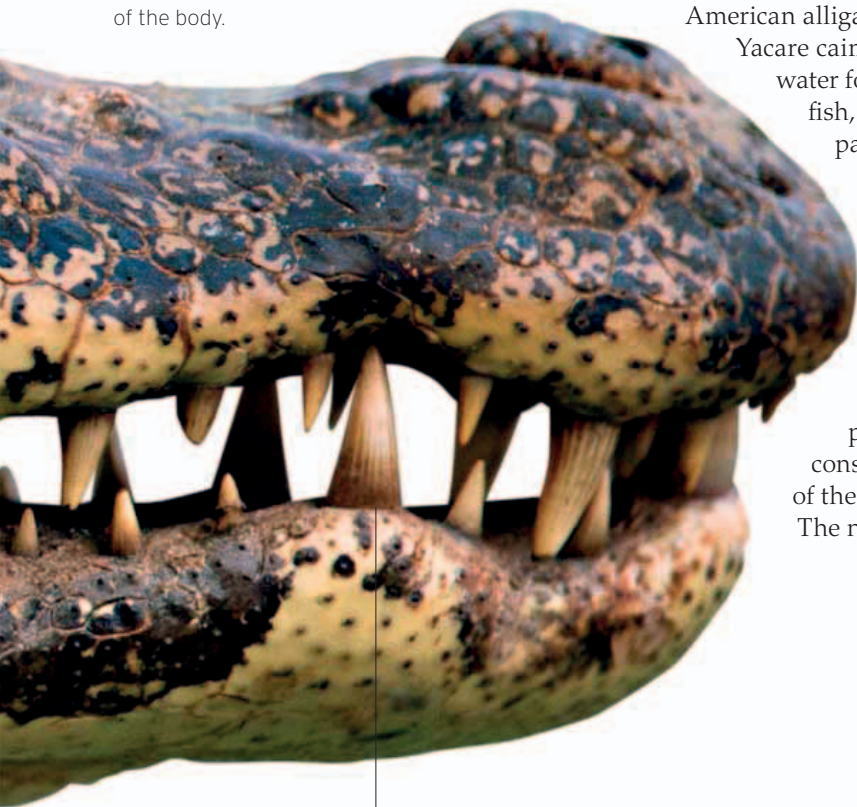
Caiman yacare

△ TOOTHY GRIN

The Yacare caiman has an average of 74 teeth. As the older ones fall out and leave gaps before replacement, the number may vary from 70 to 82.

▽ BODY ARMOR

Caiman have plates of bone, called osteoderms, that are embedded in the skin. These are smallest and most flexible on the head and underside of the body.



fourth tooth in lower jaw fits into socket in upper jaw when mouth closed

A close relative of the more northerly distributed common or spectacled caiman (*C. crocodilus*), the Yacare caiman is one of the major predators across much of its range. Its stronghold is the swampy wetlands of the Pantanal, where it is locally abundant, hauling out in large groups to bask on mats of floating plants or on banks. Its numbers here are counted in the millions—this may well be the largest crocodilian population on Earth.

Piranha prey

All five species of caiman are broad-snouted, Central and South American cousins of the North American alligator. The medium-sized Yacare caiman hunts mainly in water for snakes, amphibians, fish, and mollusks—in particular large water snails, called apple snails, that are crunched and swallowed in their shells. The local name “piranha caiman” may have arisen because the piranha makes up a considerable proportion of the Yacare caiman’s diet. The name could also reflect

its toothy appearance, similar to that of the piranha. It has sharp, conical teeth, and some of the larger teeth are still visible when its mouth is closed.

Finding new habitats

Before the global ban on the trade of wild crocodile skins in 1992, millions of Yacare caiman were killed during the 1970s and 1980s. This severe hunting pressure forced some Yacare caiman to move out of the wetlands and adapt to other habitats. These include drier grasslands, scrub, and even farmland, usually with an aquatic retreat such as a pool, ditch, or creek nearby. On land they lie in wait for passing lizards, birds, and mammals up to the size of capybara. In turn, younger Yacare caiman in particular fall prey to jaguars and anacondas.

Nesting on dry ground

The caimans’ breeding peaks during the wet season when water levels are high. After mating, the female chooses a drier site, where she constructs a mound of heat-producing rotting vegetation in which to lay her eggs. The clutch size typically varies from 20–35. Incubation takes several weeks and the female usually guards the nest from raiders such as snakes, lizards, and hawks, but not so tenaciously as some crocodilians—the American alligator, for example. In some cases, the mother has left by the time the hatchlings emerge—which occurs mostly in March—so the young caiman must fend for themselves.

- ↔ 5–10 ft (1.5–3 m)
- ⚖ 55–120 lb (25–55 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐟 Fish, birds, mammals
- 🏠 🌿 🌊



C. to S. South America

A caiman will get through up to **40 sets of teeth** in its **lifetime**